

16 shall surely live, he shall not die. None of his sins that he hath committed shall be mentioned unto him : he hath done
 17 that which is lawful and right ; he shall surely live. Yet the children of thy people say, The way of the Lord is not equal :
 18 but *as for* them, their way is not equal. When the righteous turneth from his righteousness, and committeth iniquity, he
 19 shall even die thereby. But if the wicked turn from his wickedness, and do that which is lawful and right, he shall
 20 live thereby. Yet ye say, The way of the Lord is not equal. O ye house of Israel, I will judge you every one after his ways.

21 And it came to pass in the twelfth year of our captivity, in the tenth *month*, in the fifth *day* of the month, *that* one that had escaped out of Jerusalem came unto me, saying,
 22 The city is smitten. Now the hand of the LORD was upon

nant sense of enjoyment of the favour of God and the external prosperity which is the reflection and seal of it.

16. Cf. xviii. 22.

shall be mentioned] Or, **remembered against him**, as v. 13.

17. Cf. xviii. 25, 29.

18, 19. These verses sum up the whole principles of the passage, cf. xviii. 26, 27. On v. 20 cf. xviii. 25, 29.

21, 22. Fugitives from Judaea arrive among the exiles announcing that the city had fallen. This confirmation of all the prophet's anticipations, which the exiles had received with so much incredulity, opened his mouth, gave him confidence to speak before his fellow exiles. And he announces what shall be the fate of those left in the land (vv. 23—29).

21. The date here given is about a year and a half after the city's fall. Considering the constant intercourse between the mother country and the exiles this period is very long. Some MSS. as well as the Syr. read *eleventh* year, leaving about six months for the news to travel by messenger. (Eleven and twelve are easily confused in Heb.).

our captivity] That of Jehoiachin, ch. i. 2. "One that had escaped," lit. the *fugitive*, may refer to one or more, cf. xxiv. 26.

22. Though the date is inserted here, it is probably to be understood as applicable to the whole chapter, for vv. 1, 2 the prophet is commanded to speak publicly to the children of his people. In the evening he felt the hand of the Lord upon him, he fell into an excitation. Thoughts such as those in vv. 1—20 of the new Israel that God would create and of the conditions of belonging to it filled his mind. He was well aware that the city's fall was inevitable, to him it was as good as fallen. And full of the new thoughts of the future he felt himself standing before his fellow exiles with an impulse strong upon him to speak to them of this future in the name of the Lord. In the

me in the evening, afore he that was escaped came; and had opened my mouth, until *he* came to me in the morning; and my mouth was opened, and I was no more dumb. Then the word of the LORD came unto me, saying, Son of man, they that inhabit those wastes of the land of Israel speak, saying, Abraham was one, and he inherited the land; but we *are* many; the land is given us for inheritance. Wherefore say unto them, Thus saith the Lord GOD; Ye ²³₂₄

morning the fugitives arrived with the confirmation of all his past predictions.

until he came to me] **should come**: against his coming, Ex. vii. 15.
no more dumb] i.e. silent, Ps. xxxix. 2; Is. liii. 7.

23—29. The confirmation by the fugitives of all his previous predictions gave the prophet boldness to speak anew, and what he says is but a continuation of that which he had said before, and had been so literally confirmed. He had predicted the city's fall because of its sins, and his prophecy had been verified; those remaining in the land continue in the sins for which the city fell, and its fate shall certainly overtake them. The judgment must be carried out till the offences cease. But the teaching of these verses is the natural supplement also to that in vv. 1—20. Those remaining in the land presume that they shall inherit the land because they are in it, notwithstanding their evil conduct: the inheritance of the land will be given on different conditions (vv. 1—20, cf. xxxvi. 25—38, xxxvii. 23).

24. Regarding those remaining in the land even before the fall of the city, cf. xi. 5—12, 14—21; Jer. xxiv. Those remaining in the land express their confident hopes. Though reduced in numbers they are still many in comparison of the single individual Abraham. Yet he was multiplied in such a way as to take possession of the land; much more may they hope yet to assert their claims to it. They perhaps hardly argued on mere natural probabilities; they felt themselves the heirs of the promises made to Abraham, and in spite of disasters hoped that Jehovah would fulfil them to them. They display the same temper as the people had always shewn; they have a faith in Jehovah but no knowledge of what Jehovah is (Am. v. 14; Hos. iv. 1; Jer. iv. 22, v. 2, 4). Another prophet of this age applies the strange history of Abraham and his multiplication to comfort "the few men of Israel" who followed after righteousness, Is. li. 2.

inhabit those wastes] The ruined cities chiefly, v. 27; but cf. xxxvi. 4.

the land is given us] Words of confident anticipation.

25. The claim of the remnant is repudiated by Ezek. with indignation. They persist in the sins for which their country fell, and the same judgment shall overtake them.

eat with the blood, and lift up your eyes toward your idols,
 26 and shed blood: and shall ye possess the land? Ye stand
 upon your sword, ye work abomination, and ye defile every
 one his neighbour's wife: and shall ye possess the land?
 27 Say thou thus unto them, Thus saith the Lord God; *As*
 I live, surely *they* that *are* in the wastes shall fall by the
 sword, and him that *is* in the open field will I give to the
 beasts to be devoured, and *they* that *be* in the forts and in
 28 the caves shall die of the pestilence. For I will lay the
 land most desolate, and the pomp of her strength shall
 cease; and the mountains of Israel shall be desolate, that

ye eat with the blood] i.e. eat flesh slaughtered in such a way that the blood remains in it. According to the law animals had to be slaughtered in such a way as to drain away the blood, which was poured into the ground, where not dashed upon the altar. An example of a prohibited way of slaughtering was breaking the neck, Is. lxvi. 3. Cf. Lev. xvii. 10, xix. 26; Deut. xii. 16; 1 Sam. xiv. 32. See on xviii. 6, 11, 15, xxii. 9.

lift up your eyes] See xviii. 6. On "shed blood" xxii. 6, 9.

26. *stand upon your sword*] Hardly means, the footing on which ye deal with men is the sword; but probably, ye occupy yourselves with the sword, cf. xlv. 24.

work abomination] The term is mostly applied to religious practices contrary to the pure religion of Jehovah. On the other sin named cf. xviii. 6, xxii. 11. Verses 25, 26 are wanting in LXX. The passage is vigorous and apart from the anomalous form "ye work" (where *fem. n* is due to following *t*) altogether unsuspicious. The omission in LXX. may have arisen from the eye of the translator straying from the words "Lord God" *v.* 25 to the same words *v.* 27.

27. The "wastes" are the desolate cities; those that still hover about these ruins shall be slain by the enemy. The "open field" is the country, now depopulated and "the possession of wild beasts;" and the "forts," coupled with caves, are the natural fastnesses of the land. Those taking refuge there shall die of the pestilence, due to crowding and famine. The remnant shall be exterminated from the land.

28. Cf. vii. 24, xxiv. 21, xxx. 6, 7. The "mountains of Israel" are the mountain land of Israel.

30—33. Demeanour of the people towards the prophet.

The confirmation which the fall of the city gave to the prophet's past predictions awakened the interest of his fellow exiles in him and his words. They congregated together in knots under the shadow of the walls and in the doors of the houses discussing his sayings. Recent events had given him a more prominent place in their thoughts. There

none shall pass through. Then shall they know that I *am* ²⁹ the LORD, when I have laid the land most desolate because of all their abominations which they have committed.

Also, thou son of man, the children of thy people still ³⁰ are talking against thee by the walls and in the doors of the houses, and speak one to another, every one to his brother, saying, Come, I pray you, and hear what *is* the word that cometh forth from the LORD. And they come unto thee as ³¹ the people cometh, and they sit before thee *as* my people, and they hear thy words, but they will not do them: for with their mouth they shew much love, *but* their heart goeth after their covetousness. And lo, thou *art* unto them as a ³² very lovely song *of* one that hath a pleasant voice, and can play well on an instrument: for they hear thy words, but they do them not. And when this cometh to pass, (lo, it ³³ will come) then shall they know that a prophet hath been among them.

was something also in the new truths he was uttering, in his outlook into the future and in his appeals to the individual mind, causing each to turn his eyes inward upon himself, that touched them and awakened a certain reality of concern. Still it was in the main curiosity rather than genuine seriousness that led them to listen to him. There was a certain charm, more perhaps in the kind of future presented by the prophet than in his manner of presenting it, which was like sweet music; but though they listened the drift of their minds was too steadily set in another direction to be changed.

30. *are talking against thee*] the children of thy people who talk of thee. The construction has a certain inconsequence in it. On "talk" cf. Mal. iii. 16. The "walls" afforded a shade, under which men gathered for conversation.

one to another] The form "one" is Chaldee rather than Heb. The clause says the same thing as next clause and is wanting in LXX.

31. On "come unto thee" cf. viii. 1, xiv. 1, xx. 1.

as my people] The construction is very hard. LXX. omits.

with their mouth...love] The language is peculiar, but can hardly have any other sense. LXX. Syr. read: *for falsehood is in their mouth and their heart &c.* The term "covetousness" or gain has, especially in later books, the general sense of advantage, self-advancement, Is. lvi. 11.

32. *lovely song of one*] lit. a lovely song; one that hath. The comparison "like a lovely song" is as usual inexact; "like" merely indicates the circumstances—as when there is a lovely song. The prophet is compared to the singer as A. V.

33. *when this cometh*] but when it cometh to pass. The general *it* (fem. as usual in general references) is the judgment or crisis, the